

Guidelines for Reporting About Network Data (GRAND)

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Network research has grown rapidly across multiple topics and disciplines in the 21st century. Although this growth has brought new insights and diversity to network research, it has also introduced challenges in clearly communicating about networks. Following the lead of other rapidly-growing methods (e.g., PRISMA for meta-analysis), this manuscript describes a large-scale collaborative effort to develop Guidelines for Reporting About Network Data (GRAND). These guidelines were developed by a 15-member working group in collaboration with a large community of network scholars (the GRAND Consortium) through a series of literature reviews, surveys, and feedback sessions. The resulting guidelines are presented in this manuscript, with supporting materials available at <https://www.grand-statement.org>. They are intended to facilitate clarity and transparency in network research reported in scientific documents by providing researchers, editors, and peer reviewers with guidance about the information that should always be reported.

Keywords: network science, reporting guidelines, social network

Introduction

Social network analysis (e.g., [Moreno & Jennings, 1934](#)) and network science (e.g., [Erdős & Rényi, 1959](#)) have long histories, but research in these fields has increased dramatically in the 21st century. Network research can now be found in nearly all areas of the social and physical sciences, as well as in the humanities and arts. The increased volume and

diversity of network research has substantially enriched the field and our understanding of the social and natural worlds. However, it has also introduced a challenge: clearly communicating about networks.

This is not a new challenge in the sciences. One widely adopted solution has been the collaborative development of a set of communication guidelines, for example: the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic reviews and Meta-Analyses guidelines (PRISMA; [Moher, Liberati, Tetzlaff, Altman, & Group, 2009](#)), the American Association for Public Opinion Research's standard definitions for surveys ([American Association for Public Opinion Research, 2023](#)), the American

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Psychological Association’s Journal Article Reporting Standards (JARS; Kazak, 2018), and datasheets for datasets (Geburu et al., 2021). While these guidelines have proven useful in their respective fields, no comprehensive guidelines exist for reporting about network data.

This paper reports on a large-scale collaborative effort to develop *Guidelines for Reporting About Network Data* (GRAND). We begin by describing the goals and desired characteristics of such guidelines. We then describe three phases of development: a review and scoping survey, a working group, and public feedback. Finally, we present the completed guidelines and discuss their intended use.

Goals

We aimed to achieve three broad goals by developing and disseminating GRAND. First, by helping authors describe the networks they use in published research, these guidelines are intended to *facilitate readers’ understanding*. After reading a GRAND-compliant description of a network, readers are more likely to understand what the network is intended to represent, and thus how to interpret the results of analyses performed on the network. This is particularly important during the peer review process, where clarity can lead to faster and more accurate evaluations of a submitted manuscript.

Second, by helping authors uniformly describe the networks they use, these guidelines are intended to *facilitate automated and manual data extraction* for the systematic review and meta-analysis of network findings. For example, GRAND-compliant descriptions will help avoid cases where “summaries of social network characteristics were [not] sufficiently homogenous to undertake statistical meta-analysis” (Fletcher, Bonell, & Sorhaindo, 2011, p. 549), thereby allowing network characteristics and findings to be compared and aggregated for greater precision (Kovacevic, Shevchyk, & Neal, 2026).

Finally, by providing guidance to authors about which basic features of a network should be reported, these guidelines are intended to *facilitate proper re-use* of shared network data (Neal et al., 2024). For example, GRAND-compliant descriptions will help future researchers identify and prioritize using existing network data with node and edge definitions that are appropriate for their research question.

To achieve these goals, we aimed for GRAND to have three characteristics. First, the guidelines should be *interdisciplinary*. That is, they should be applicable to networks describing different types of systems (e.g., social, biological, physical) and examined from different orientations (e.g., social network analysis, network science). Second, the guidelines should be *inclusive*. That is, they should be applicable to many different types of networks (e.g., whole, ego, higher-order, dynamic) collected and recorded in different ways (e.g., quantitative, qualitative). Finally, the guidelines should be *limited*. That is, they should be restricted to the

minimum information that should always be reported, and that is straightforward to assess using widely-accepted methods, leaving other context-specific details to the discretion of authors, peer reviewers, and editors.

Process

To develop GRAND, we mirrored the process used to develop the widely-adopted PRISMA reporting guidelines for systematic reviews and meta-analyses (Moher et al., 2009). First, we began with a review of existing guidelines and recommendations, and conducted a scoping survey to identify existing consensus and practices in reporting. Second, we formed a demographically and intellectually diverse working group to develop a draft set of guidelines. Finally, we conducted a series of additional surveys and listening sessions to solicit feedback and iteratively refine the draft guidelines.

Phase 1: Review and scoping survey

A review of the literature identified four existing sets of guidelines for network research that varied in their length and focus. First, the Network Cards guidelines (Bagrow & Ahn, 2022) proposed a list of 26 items that researchers should include in a standardized summary document, with a particular focus on reporting structural metrics (e.g., clustering coefficient, diameter, assortativity). Second, the Social Networks in Health Research (SoNHR) guidelines (Luke et al., 2023) proposed a list of 18 items based on a review of health studies and a survey of health researchers, with a particular focus on epistemological issues (e.g., “Make the value of a network analysis apparent”). Third, the standards for psychological network analysis (Burger et al., 2023) proposed a list of 18 subsections to consider including in methods and results sections, with a focus only on manuscripts reporting the analysis of networks of psychological variables’ statistical relationships with one another. Finally, the REDES guidelines (Aliева et al., 2026) proposed a list of 7 items based on a review of network research published in the Spanish-language journal *REDES*, with a focus on harmonizing terminology used in the social sciences. These lists offered useful starting points for the participatory development of an interdisciplinary set of guidelines. Many of the items that were common across these existing lists were retained in GRAND (e.g., define the edges), while idiosyncratic items were included in early drafts of GRAND but were ultimately removed (e.g., structural metrics, epistemology).

Two scoping surveys were conducted in Spring 2023 to understand network researchers’ current beliefs about what information should be reported in research publications describing network data. The first survey was a census of all 237 board members of two network professional associations (INSNA and NetSci) and seven network journals (*Applied Network Science*, *Connections*, *Journal of Complex*

Networks, *Journal of Social Structure*, *Network Science*, *Social Networks*, *Social Network Analysis and Mining*). The second survey was a convenience sample distributed via social media (Mastodon, Twitter) and network listservs (SOC-NET, REDES, cna2023, siam-ns). Collectively, these surveys yielded 306 responses from respondents who were diverse with respect to gender, discipline, and orientation and had an average of 15 years experience conducting network research.

A majority of respondents (74%) agreed that having guidelines for reporting about network data would be useful, while only a minority believed that such guidelines could be sufficiently general that they would apply across disciplines and topics (47%), or that they would be adopted by network researchers (41%). There was broad agreement that researchers should always report how the data were collected or generated (90%), the definition (90%) and count (90%) of nodes, and the definition (92%) and count (75%) of edges. There was also broad agreement that researchers *do not* always need to report structural metrics such as the clustering coefficient (12%), mean path length (12%), diameter (9%), or modularity (5%). Highlighting differing disciplinary conventions, respondents were mixed about the importance of some items, for example, whether researchers should report the network's density (34%) or mean degree (35%). These results suggested that developing network reporting guidelines was worthwhile and identified points of broad agreement, while also highlighting issues that required further consideration (e.g., what metric of connectivity should be reported, if any) and potential challenges to guideline development (e.g., generality, adoption).

Phase 2: Working group

In early 2025 the first author recruited the remaining named authors to form a working group. Members of the working group compiled an initial set of guidelines based on the results of the phase 1 review and survey. Then, during quarterly virtual meetings and in-person meetings at the 2025 Sunbelt (Paris) and NetSci (Maastricht) conferences, they iteratively refined these initial guidelines by adding, removing, and revising items based on working group discussions and the results of public feedback.

Phase 3: Public feedback

To solicit public feedback on GRAND, the working group held a listening session at the 2025 NetSci conference in Maastricht, and conducted feedback surveys in November 2025 ($N = 41$), March 2026 ($N = 110$), and June 2026 ($N = 171$). In each feedback survey, respondents reviewed each item in the then-current draft, indicating their level of agreement with including the item and providing feedback on ways to improve it, as well as offering an overall assessment of the guidelines. In the first survey, on average respondents

agreed with 83.5% of the items. Following revision by the working group, in the second survey, on average respondents agreed with 94.6% of the items. The working group undertook a final round of revisions based on feedback provided in the second survey to obtain the penultimate guidelines. In the final survey, 97% of respondents endorsed these guidelines, while providing minor suggestions that were incorporated by the working group in the final guidelines.

Guidelines

The final guidelines (GRAND v1.0.0) are composed of 25 items organized in four sections: Data, Nodes, Edges, and Transformations. The 'Data' section (see Table 1) contains 7 reporting items related to the dataset as a whole, including whether the data are empirical or synthetic, when and where the data are intended to represent, and where the data can be obtained. The 'Nodes' section (see Table 2) contains 5 reporting items related to the nodes or vertices, including the count and what they are intended to represent. The 'Edges' section (see Table 3) contains 7 reporting items related to the edges or arcs, including the count and what they are intended to represent, as well as selected attributes (e.g., direction, weight). Finally, the 'Transformations' section (see Table 4) contains 6 reporting items related to transformations performed on raw data to obtain the analytic data, including symmetrizing originally directed edges or dichotomizing originally weighted edges.

These guidelines were designed narrowly to identify only those items that should always be reported, even when a given dataset has been described elsewhere, or when a well-known network is being used as an example or case study. As a result, they omit many details that readers may want to know. In practice, the research question and disciplinary conventions will require reporting additional information that is not included in the guidelines. For example, the guidelines do not include reporting any structural metrics (e.g., density, clustering coefficient, etc.) because the meaningfulness of these values depends heavily on the nature of the network and research context. Such values can and should be reported when they are meaningful and relevant, but are not necessary to report in *all* network research.

The guidelines include such common and fundamental information that many researchers may already routinely report it, in which case GRAND serves primarily as a helpful reminder and checklist. However, to promote clarity, we recommend that the guideline items be reported in the main document, rather than in an appendix or supplementary materials. This information may be scattered throughout the text in contextually appropriate places, or may be reported together in a single summary paragraph or table. This should be feasible even in relatively short documents with strict word limits because multiple guideline items can be reported very compactly. For example, in the case of the Zachary Karate

Table 1

Reporting Guidelines for Data

#	Item	Reporting guideline
1.1	Data	If the data are empirical , report the method originally used to collect them.
1.2	Ethics	If the data are synthetic , report the data generating model and the values of its parameters. If the collection or use of these data could present ethical concerns , report whether institutional or ethical approval was obtained, the approving entity, and approval date.
1.3	Multiple	If the data contain a panel of networks representing the same nodes at different times , report the number of waves and the interval(s) between waves. If the data contain multiple networks that each represent the same type of system , report the number of networks.
1.4	Location	If empirical (see 1.1) , report the location that the data are intended to represent, at a substantively and ethically appropriate level of resolution.
1.5	Time	If empirical (see 1.1) , report the time(s) that the data are intended to represent, at a substantively and ethically appropriate level of resolution.
1.6	Availability	Report the URL or DOI linking to a repository where the data or data-generating code are available, or explain why the data are not available in a repository.
1.7	Citation	If the data have an independent citation , provide a citation to the data.

Table 2

Reporting Guidelines for Nodes

#	Item	Reporting guideline
2.1	Nodes	Report what the nodes are intended to represent. If the nodes represent more than one type of entity , describe the network as N-mode and report what each type of node is intended to represent.
2.2	Size	Report the number of nodes. If multiple (see 1.3) , report the number of nodes in each wave/network if practical; otherwise report the mean, standard deviation, and range.
2.3	Boundary	If multimode (see 2.1) , report this item separately for each type of node. If empirical (see 1.1) , report how the set of nodes that should be included in the network was defined.
2.4	Missing	If nodes that should be included in the network are missing from the network (see 2.3) , report the percent or number of missing nodes, or the percent or number of present nodes (i.e., the response rate). If multiple (see 1.3) , report this value for each wave/network if practical; otherwise report the mean, standard deviation, and range.
2.5	Degree	If nodes' minimum or maximum degree is constrained by the data collection or generation design , report any restriction(s) on nodes' degree.

Table 3

Reporting Guidelines for Edges

#	Item	Reporting guideline
3.1	Edges	Report what the edges are intended to represent.
		If the edges represent more than one type of relationship , describe the network as multiplex or multilayer, and report what each type of edge is intended to represent.
3.2	Direction	Report whether the edges are directed or undirected.
		If directed , report what the direction of the edge means.
		If multiplex (see 3.1) , report this item separately for each type of edge.
3.3	Weight	Report whether the edges are weighted, unweighted, or signed.
		If weighted , report the meaning, scale of measurement, and mean, standard deviation, and range of weights.
		If signed , report the meaning of positive edges and the meaning of negative edges
		If multiplex (see 3.1) , report this item separately for each type of edge.
3.4	Non-simple	If the network contains self-loops or multi-edges , report that they are present and what they represent.
3.5	Bipartite	If multimode (see 2.1) , report where edges can be located.
3.6	Hypergraph	If the network is a hypergraph , report that the network is a hypergraph.
3.7	Number	Report the number of edges present.
		If multiple (see 1.3) , report the number of edges in each wave/network if practical; otherwise report the mean, standard deviation, and range.
		If multiplex (see 3.1) or signed (see 3.3) , report this item separately for each type of edge.
		If hypergraph (see 3.6) , report the number of (hyper)edges, and the mean and standard deviation of the size of the hyperedges.

Club network, 10 separate guideline items can be reported in a single sentence: “The Zachary (1977) Karate Club network was collected between 1970 and 1972 via observation in an American university and contains 34 nodes that represent people, which are connected by 78 unweighted and undirected edges that represent interaction outside of club activities.”

Tables 1-4 present the complete guidelines, however they are also available at <https://www.grand-statement.org> in three alternative formats. First, to facilitate dissemination, a printable four-page short-form contains hyperlinks with definitions of key network terms. Second, to facilitate use, a printable five-page long-form also includes hyperlinked explanatory notes and references for each reporting guideline, and an FAQ for using the guidelines. Finally, to facilitate use in specific cases, a custom set of guidelines that contains only the items relevant to a specific dataset can be generated by answering a few basic questions using a web-based form.

Conclusion

We expect that GRAND will move network research forward by ensuring that data are described clearly and consistently across fields and topics each time they are used. Moreover, we expect more targeted benefits when GRAND is used by its two primary audiences: authors and editors. First, new network scholars will develop skills in scientific writing and established network scholars will ensure that their work is accessible across disciplinary boundaries by using GRAND as a reminder of the details to include in their manuscripts. Second, editors can improve the efficiency and usefulness of the review process by asking authors to provide the information recommended by GRAND prior to requesting peer reviews.

The overarching goal of GRAND is to facilitate clarity and transparency in network research. However, because network research is constantly evolving, GRAND should

Table 4*Reporting Guidelines for Transformations*

#	Item	Reporting guideline
4.1	Symmetrized	If directed edges in raw data were transformed into undirected edges in the final analytic network , report the transformation method and the percent of connected dyads that had non-reciprocal edges before the transformation.
4.2	Dichotomized	If weighted edges in raw data were transformed into unweighted edges in the final analytic network , report the transformation method and the number or percent of edges that were deleted as a result of the transformation.
4.3	Projected	If the final analytic network was generated from other data such that edges represent similarities, co-occurrences, or statistical associations , report the transformation method.
4.4	Excluded	If any nodes or edges that were present in raw data have been excluded from the final analytic network , report the exclusion criteria and number or percent of nodes or edges that were excluded.
4.5	Aggregated	If any nodes or edges that were separate in raw data have been aggregated in the final analytic network , report the aggregation method.
4.6	Imputed	If any nodes or edges were unmeasured in raw data, and their presence or absence was imputed or inferred in the final analytic network , report the imputation method and the number or percent of nodes or edges that were imputed.

be viewed as a living document that can be updated and expanded periodically to remain current with developments in the field. The guidelines and process described in this manuscript provides a template future revisions.

Data Availability Statement. Results from the scoping survey, public feedback surveys, and earlier drafts of GRAND are available at <https://osf.io/zjwm7/>.

Ethics Statement. All study activities were approved as exempt by the Michigan State University Institutional Review Board (21 February 2023, STUDY00008880).

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